

10 > Choose your format and design your podcast

accuracy. They are ideal for narrative work, technical explainers and sensitive subjects. The danger is sounding as though you are reading.

Detailed outlines offer a useful middle ground: prepare the sequence, facts and examples, then speak naturally. Pure improvisation often produces repetition and weak endings.

For most beginners, a detailed outline is the safest starting point.

Try this workflow:

- **Step 1:** Write the episode's single main promise.
- **Step 2:** List three to five points needed to deliver it.
- **Step 3:** Add examples, statistics, stories or questions under each point.
- **Step 4:** Write the opening and closing more carefully than the middle.
- **Step 5:** Record once without trying to sound perfect.

Think about audio and video

If you intend to publish video, design for it from the beginning. A podcast recorded around a noisy café table may be perfectly understandable as an audio concept but difficult to film well.



Decide whether video is central or secondary. If central, consider framing, lighting, visual branding and whether guests can appear on camera. If secondary, a simpler single-camera recording may be enough.

Do not allow video requirements to damage the audio. Listeners should still understand the episode without seeing a screen.

Similarly, avoid phrases such as “as you can see here” unless you immediately describe what the audio audience is missing.

ALSO WORTH DECIDING

- **Language:** Pick English, an Indian language, or a code-mixed style — and stay consistent. Switching mid-season confuses both listeners and discovery algorithms.
- **Clip strategy:** Decide early whether each episode must yield 30- to 60-second vertical clips. This shapes framing, seating and pacing before you record.
- **Sponsor slots:** Reserve fixed pre-roll and mid-roll positions now, even without advertisers, so inserting ads later needs no re-edit.
- **Numbering and titles:** Choose one convention — episode number, guest name or topic — and keep it uniform for search and back-catalogue navigation.
- **Remote or in-person:** Remote recording widens your guest pool but limits audio quality; in-person sounds better but complicates scheduling.
- **Evergreen mix:** Balance timely episodes with ones still worth hearing a year later.

Stress-Test the Format Before Launch

Record a pilot before making the format public.

Then listen to it like a stranger.

Ask:

- Does the episode begin quickly enough?
- Is the purpose clear within the first minute?
- Are any sections repetitive?
- Does the host sound natural?
- Is the duration justified?
- Would the structure work for ten more episodes?
- How difficult was the episode to produce?

If one 30-minute episode took three days to edit, ask whether that workload is sustainable.

Don't forget one thing...

Before moving ahead, finalise four things. First, choose your primary format and one optional secondary format. Second, decide your target episode-length range and publishing cadence. Third, create a standard episode structure containing no more than eight recurring sections. Finally, complete a one-page show bible and record a rough pilot using that plan.

You are not trying to create the perfect podcast yet. You are designing a machine you can operate repeatedly. The best format is one that suits your listener, showcases your strengths and remains practical after the excitement of launch has worn off. **d**